

The Game in Fifteen Minutes

Field, scoring, and clock: the board the whole game is played on, and the rules that make a team kneel, kick, or sprint out of bounds.

Late in the fourth quarter, the team that leads by four hands the ball to its running back. He breaks into the open along the sideline with nobody near him, and instead of running out of bounds or for the end zone, he slows down and slides to the turf in the middle of the field. The announcer *praises* him. On the next possession the other team completes a pass, and the receiver throws himself out of bounds at the first touch of a defender, and the announcer praises him too. A minute later a coach sends his kicker on to try a short field goal on fourth-and-goal from the 3 and the home crowd boos. None of it makes sense until you know the board the game is played on: a field with a particular shape, a scoring system with a gap between seven points and three, and a clock that runs or stops according to rules the broadcast never stops to explain. This chapter explains them. It's the shortest tour in the course, and everything after it depends on it.

You'll be able to...

- Name every marking on the field, from the end line to the hash marks, and say what each one is for.
- Find the **field side** and the **boundary side** on any snap, and explain why the ball's position across the field changes what an offense can do.
- Score any play (touchdown, extra point, two-point try, field goal, safety), and explain why the gap between seven points and three shapes so many decisions.
- Say before each snap whether the game clock is running, and why.
- Tell the game clock from the play clock on the score bug, and know what each one is counting down.
- Describe the shape of a game: coin toss, kickoff, possessions, quarters, halftime, and overtime.

Four words before we start

A few words have to come before this chapter can teach anything. Each gets its own chapter later; for now a one-line version is enough.

- A **snap** is the center handing or tossing the ball back between his legs to start a play. Every play from the field starts with one (What a Play Really Is covers who decides what happens next).
- The **line of scrimmage** is the imaginary line across the field through the ball before the snap. The offense lines up on one side of it, the defense on the other (Downs, Distance, and Field Position).
- A **down** is one play. The offense gets four downs to gain ten yards; make it and it gets a fresh set (a **first down**); fail and the ball goes to the other team. That whole system is the next chapter's subject.
- The **offense** is the team with the ball; the **defense** is the team trying to stop it. On kicking plays they're called **special teams**, and the positions on all three units are introduced in The Twenty-Two.

That's enough to read the board.

The board: 120 yards by 53½

An NFL field is a rectangle 360 feet long and 160 feet wide: 120 yards by 53½.¹ Almost every line painted on it exists for a reason you can see on a broadcast. Here is the whole thing from above, with the offense attacking to the right, the way every diagram in this course is oriented when the field lies sideways.

¹*Official Playing Rules of the National Football League* (2026), Rule 1, Sections 1–2 (field 360 by 160 feet; goal lines 10 yards from the end lines; yard lines every 5 yards; 1-yard marks; bottoms of the numbers 12 yards from the sideline; the 1-yard line two yards from the middle of each goal line), and the rulebook's field diagram notes (arrows beside the numbers pointing toward the goal line): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

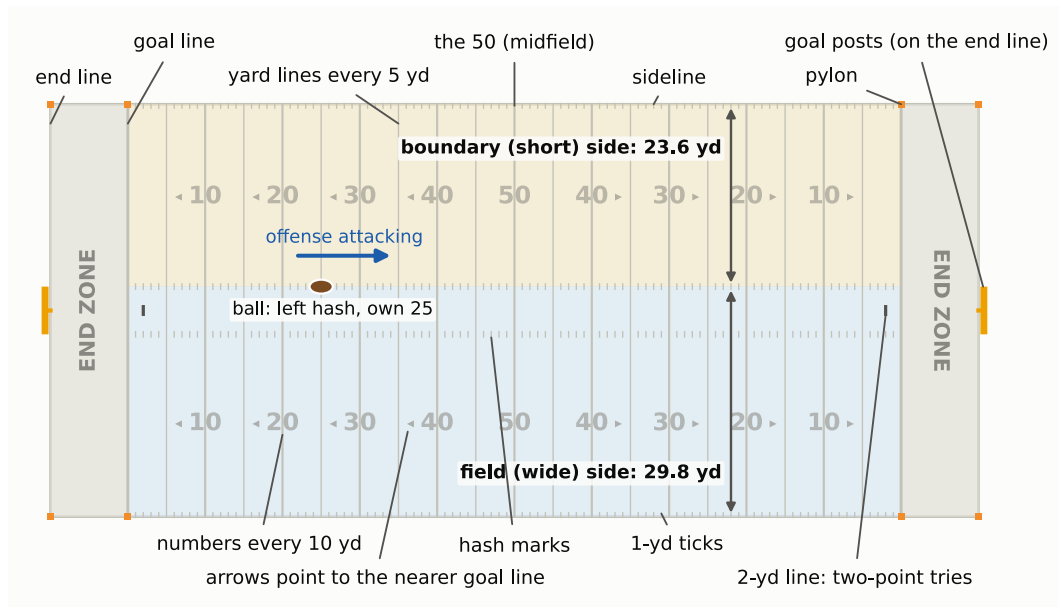


Figure 1: The whole field from above, offense attacking right. The ball sits on the offense's left hash at its own 25, which splits the field into the boundary (short) side above the ball and the field (wide) side below it. The end zones are the grey 10-yard boxes; the goal posts stand on the end lines; the small arrows beside each number point toward the nearer goal line.

Read it from the outside in.

The edges. The long boundaries are the **sidelines** and the short ones are the **end lines**. Both lines are themselves *out of bounds*: a receiver whose toe touches the white paint of the sideline as he catches the ball has caught it out of bounds. That is why you'll see receivers tiptoe along the sideline, dragging their feet to get both of them down inside it.

The end zones. Ten yards in from each end line is a **goal line**, and the 10-yard box between the goal line and the end line is the **end zone**, the place the offense is trying to reach. The goal line is painted *inside* the end zone (its outer edge is the true goal line), so the line itself counts as end zone.² That's why the officials talk about the ball "breaking the plane": a runner scores the instant any part of the ball touches the vertical wall that rises from the front edge of that stripe, even if he's knocked backward a split second later. The orange **pylons** at the corners mark where the goal line and end line meet the sidelines, so the officials (and replay) can judge plays at the corner where the plane meets the boundary.

Yard lines and numbers. Every 5 yards a **yard line** runs from sideline to sideline, and the big numbers every 10 yards count *up* from each goal line to the 50 and back down again: 10, 20, 30, 40, 50, 40, 30, 20, 10. Because the numbers repeat, every spot needs a side: the broadcast says "first down at his *own* 25" or "at the Dallas 40". The small arrow beside each number points toward the nearer goal line, so from any camera angle you can tell which 30 you're looking at. Between the 5-yard lines, short 1-yard ticks run along each sideline and along the hash marks, so officials can spot the ball to the yard.

The middle. The two rows of ticks down the middle are the **hash marks**, which the rulebook calls the inbounds lines. They get their own section next, because they shape play design more than any other line on the field. The 1-yard dash at the 2-yard line, in the middle of the field, marks where a two-point try is snapped (more on that under scoring).

The goal posts. One bright yellow goal post stands at the back of each end zone, *on* the end line: a crossbar 10 feet off the ground and 18 feet 6 inches wide, with uprights rising 35 feet above it.³ They weren't always there. The NFL put its goal posts on the goal line in 1933, when kicking was a bigger part of the offense, and moved them back to the end line in 1974, both to stop players running into them and, mostly, to make field goals ten yards longer and nudge coaches toward going for touchdowns.⁴

² *Official Playing Rules of the NFL* (2026), Rule 1-2-3 ("Each goal line marking is to be in its end zone so that the edge of the line toward the field of play (actual goal line) is 30 feet from the inside edge of the end line") and Rule 11-2-1 (a touchdown when the ball "is on, above, or behind the plane of the opponent's goal line"): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

³ *Official Playing Rules of the NFL* (2026), Rule 1, Section 3 (crossbar "in the plane of each end line", 18 feet 6 inches long, its top 10 feet above the ground; uprights extending 35 feet above the crossbar): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

⁴ Pro Football Hall of Fame, "Evolution of the Game: Goal Posts": <https://profootballhof.com/blogs/stories-from-the-pro-football-hall-of-fame-archives/evolution-of-the-game-goal-posts>

The yellow line you see on TV isn't on the field. The broadcast paints a yellow “first-down line” onto the picture, and a blue line at the line of scrimmage. Neither is real; the players can't see them. The real markers are on the sideline, where the chain crew holds them, and they're part of the next chapter (Downs, Distance, and Field Position).

🔥 Common misconception

“He has to carry the ball *over* the goal line.” He doesn't. The goal line is part of the end zone, so the ball only has to *touch* the front edge of the stripe while a player in bounds holds it. A runner stretching the ball out as he falls, with the ball just grazing the paint above the line, has scored, even if his body lands short. A receiver catching a pass, though, is held to the catch rules: he has to come down in bounds with control (Officiating, Replay, and the Rules of the Ball covers the catch and the replay standard).

The hash marks: why the ball is almost never in the middle

Here is a rule you've watched hundreds of times without noticing. **Every play starts with the ball on or between the hash marks.** If a runner is tackled near the sideline, the officials don't snap the next play from where he fell; they carry the ball in to the nearer hash. And because so many plays end outside the hashes, most plays begin *on* one of them: in the 2025 regular season about 45% of runs and passes were snapped from the right hash, 45% from the left, and only about 9% from somewhere in the middle.⁵ A ball spotted between the hashes stays where it was downed, which is why the middle-of-the-field snaps tend to follow plays that ended in the middle of the field.

In the NFL each row of hash marks is 70 feet 9 inches in from its sideline, which leaves the two rows only 18 feet 6 inches apart, about 6 yards and exactly the width of the goal posts.⁶ That matching width isn't decoration: from anywhere between the hashes a kicker has the posts nearly straight in front of him.

Field side and boundary side

When the ball is on a hash, the field is lopsided. On one side of the ball there are 29.8 yards of grass to the sideline; on the other, only 23.6. Coaches and broadcasters have names for the two sides:

- The **field side**, also called the **wide side**, is the side with more room: from the ball to the far sideline.
- The **boundary side**, also called the **short side**, is the side with less room: from the ball to the near sideline. The sideline is “the boundary”, and on this side it's close enough to act like an extra defender.

When the ball is in the middle, there is no field or boundary side; both sides are the same.

! Why it exists

A six-yard difference sounds small, so think about what it means for one play. On the boundary side, an offense running wide toward the sideline has 23 yards of room, and the sideline is a wall the defense can trap the runner against. A pass thrown to the boundary travels a short distance from the quarterback to the receiver. On the field side there is more room to run around the defense and to separate from a defender, but a pass to the far sideline has to travel farther in the air, which gives defenders more time to close and makes it the riskiest throw on the field. Every offense and defense plans with that asymmetry in mind:

- **Offenses** like to put their extra receivers and their outside runs toward the field side, where there's room to use them, and save quick throws to the boundary receiver for when the defense leaves him alone.
- **Defenses** answer in kind. Many teams assign their players by side rather than by left and right: a “field corner” and a “boundary corner”, a field safety and a boundary safety, each with a different job because each defends a different amount of grass. You'll meet those assignments in Coverage Fundamentals.

So before every snap, the first question to ask is simply: **which hash is the ball on?**

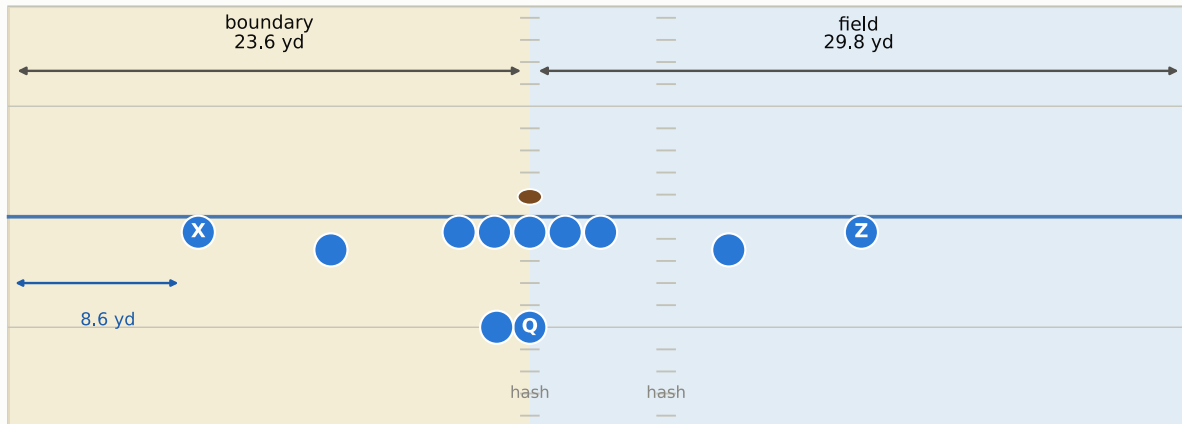
⁵Course calculation from nflverse FTN charting ([starting_hash](#)) joined to play-by-play, 2025 regular season, runs and passes only (32,941 plays): right hash 45.5%, left hash 45.0%, middle 9.4%.

⁶*Official Playing Rules of the NFL* (2026), Rule 1-2-2 (inbounds lines 70 feet 9 inches from each sideline) and Rule 1, Section 3 (crossbar 18 feet 6 inches long), which together leave the hashes exactly as far apart as the goal posts are wide: <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

NFL hashes versus college hashes

College football draws its hashes much wider apart: 60 feet from each sideline, so the rows are 40 feet (13⅓ yards) apart instead of about six.⁷ The fields are the same size, so the whole difference goes into the gap between the two sides.

NFL: hashes 6.2 yd apart



College: hashes 13.3 yd apart

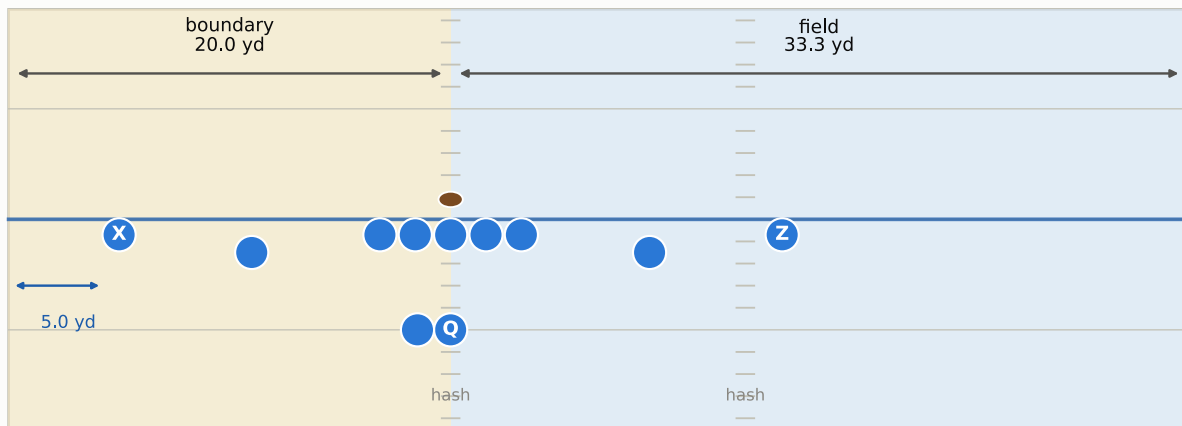


Figure 2: The same formation, ball on the left hash, on an NFL field (top) and a college field (bottom). The NFL’s narrow hashes leave the boundary side only about 6 yards smaller than the field side; college’s wide hashes make it 13 yards smaller. The boundary receiver (X), lined up 15 yards from the ball, has 8.6 yards to the sideline in the NFL and 5 in college.

That picture explains a good deal about why the college and pro games look different. In college, a ball on the hash leaves a huge field side, so college offenses spread the field and attack that open grass with option runs and wide throws, and the short side is so cramped that a receiver lined up there is nearly standing on the sideline. In the NFL the field is close to symmetrical even when the ball sits on a hash, so the pro game is played more *between* the numbers and the boundary matters a little less. When a college quarterback or receiver arrives in the NFL, one of the quiet adjustments is to a field that “feels” narrower in the middle and roomier on the short side. (High school fields split the difference: their hashes divide the width into thirds, about 17⅓ yards each.)

The NFL’s hashes weren’t always this narrow, and the history is a small lesson in why rules change. Pro football had no hash marks at all until a game in December 1932 between the Chicago Bears and the Portsmouth Spartans was moved indoors to Chicago Stadium because of a blizzard. The arena floor was only 80 yards long and cramped against the walls, so the teams agreed that any play ending near the boundary would be brought in 10 yards before the next snap. The idea worked so well that the NFL adopted inbounds lines for the 1933 season, and then kept moving them toward the middle: farther in for 1935, to 20 yards from each sideline (today’s college width) in 1945, and to the current 70 feet 9 inches in 1972. The 1972 move was sold as a gift to the

⁷Official Playing Rules of the NFL (2026), field diagram notes, item 10: “The location of the inbounds hash marks is 70’ 9” for professional football, 60’ for college football”: <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/> . High school hash marks divide the field into thirds (53 feet 4 inches from each sideline) under NFHS rules.

offense, giving it more room on the short side and taking away the steep angles on short field goals from the hash.⁸

Scoring: five ways to put points on the board

There are only five ways to score in football, and they're worth 6, 1, 2, 3 and 2 points. Where each one happens matters as much as what it's worth.

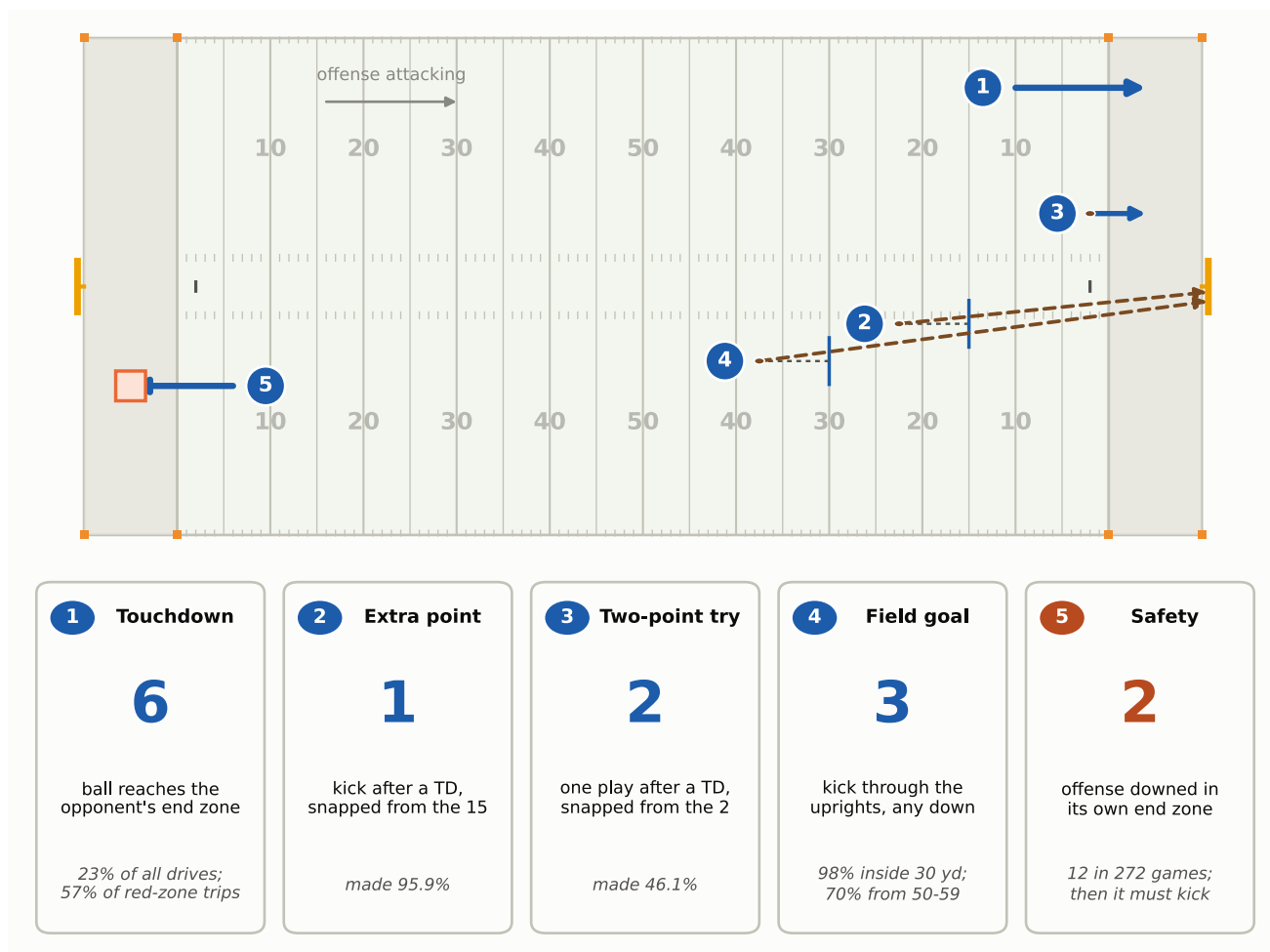


Figure 3: The five ways to score, located on the field (offense attacking right). A touchdown (1) is scored in the opponent's end zone; after it, the scoring team tries for one point by kicking (2, snapped from the 15) or two by running or passing (3, snapped from the 2). Short vertical bars mark the line of scrimmage for the kicks. A field goal (4) is kicked from wherever the offense stalls, so its distance is the line of scrimmage plus about 17 or 18 yards. A safety (5) happens at the other end: the offense downed in its own end zone. Success rates are for the 2025 regular season.

Touchdown: six points

A **touchdown** is worth six points, and it's the point of the whole exercise. A runner scores when any part of the ball, in his possession, reaches the goal line's plane; a receiver scores by completing a catch in the end zone; a defender scores by returning an interception or a fumble all the way to the other end zone.⁹ The touchdown is also the only score that earns a bonus play.

The try: one point or two

After every touchdown, the scoring team gets one more play, from close range, with no time coming off the clock. The rulebook calls it the **try**. The team chooses what kind:

⁸Wikipedia, "Hash mark (sports)", citing "Owners give offense big seven-yard boost," *Rome News-Tribune* (AP), March 24, 1972: [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hash_mark_\(sports\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hash_mark_(sports)); Wikipedia, "1972 NFL season" (hash marks moved to 70 feet 9 inches, the width of the goal posts, "cutting down on severe angles for short field goal attempts"): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/1972_NFL_season. On the December 1932 Bears–Spartans playoff game at Chicago Stadium and the 1933 adoption of inbounds lines, see the Pro Football Hall of Fame's history pages: <https://www.profootballhof.com/football-history/>

⁹*Official Playing Rules of the NFL* (2026), Rule 11, Sections 1–2 (touchdown 6, field goal 3, safety 2, try 1 or 2; how a touchdown is scored): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

- An **extra point**, also called the **PAT** (“point after touchdown”), is a kick. Since 2015 the NFL has snapped it from the 15-yard line, which with the hold 7 or 8 yards behind the snap makes it about a 33-yard kick. It’s worth one point.
- A **two-point conversion** is a single run or pass snapped from the 2-yard line. Get the ball into the end zone and it’s worth two.

You might expect the two-point try to be the obvious choice, since it pays double. The rates say otherwise. In 2025 kickers made 95.9% of extra points and offenses converted 46.1% of their 128 two-point tries.¹⁰ That makes the expected value almost identical: about 0.96 points for the kick and about 0.92 for the two-point try. Because the average payoff is a wash, the choice depends on **the score**, not on the odds. A team that trails by 8 late and scores a touchdown needs the two-point try to tie; a team that trails by 14 and scores might go for two to make the next touchdown worth a lead instead of a tie. Those decisions belong to The Clock, the Two-Minute Drill, and Fourth Down and Win Probability and Decision Analysis; for now, notice that when a team lines up at the 2 instead of the 15 after a touchdown, the coach has looked at the scoreboard.

The near-tie between the two options is no accident. Until 2014 the NFL snapped the extra point from the 2-yard line, kickers made 99.3% of them, and the play had become a formality the league wanted to make interesting again. In 2015 the owners voted 30–2 to move the kick back to the 15 and, at the same time, to let the defense return a blocked kick or a failed two-point try for two points of its own. The make rate fell to 94.2% that first season.¹¹ The two-point option itself is older in college and in the old American Football League than in the NFL, which only adopted it in 1994.¹²

Field goal: three points

A **field goal** is worth three points: a place kick from scrimmage, held on the ground by a teammate, that goes over the crossbar and between the uprights. It can be tried on any down, but in practice it’s a fourth-down play, the offense’s way of cashing in a drive that stalled short of the end zone.

The kick’s distance is always longer than it sounds, because the posts are at the *back* of the end zone and the kick is held 7 or 8 yards behind the line of scrimmage. Add about 17 or 18 to the yard line: a field goal from the opponent’s 30 is a 47- or 48-yard kick. And the distance matters a great deal. In 2025 NFL kickers made about 98% of their kicks shorter than 30 yards, 93% from 30 to 39, 84% from 40 to 49, 70% from 50 to 59, and a little over half of their (few) kicks from 60 and beyond.¹³ A missed field goal is not free, either: the other team takes over at the spot of the kick (or at its own 20 if the kick was from inside the 20), a 7- or 8-yard loss of field position on top of the points not scored.¹⁴

Safety: two points for the defense

The rarest score is the **safety**. If the offense’s ball carrier is tackled in his own end zone, or the offense commits a foul there, or the ball goes out of bounds behind its own goal line, the defense scores two points. Then comes the part that makes a safety sting: the team that gave it up must kick the ball away to the team that scored, from its own 20-yard line, so the scoring team usually gets the ball back in good field position. Two points *and* possession.¹⁵ It doesn’t happen often (12 safeties in 272 regular-season games in 2025), but a pinned offense starting at its own 2 is always one bad play from one.

Why seven-versus-three is the game’s central tension

Put the numbers side by side. A touchdown and its kick are worth about seven points. A field goal is worth three. When an offense drives to within 20 yards of the end zone, the area called the red zone, it is almost always going to get *something*, and the whole fight is over whether it gets seven or three. In 2025, of the drives that reached the red zone, 57% ended in a touchdown and 30% in a field goal; most of the rest ended in a failed fourth down or a turnover.¹⁶ Every one of those field goals is four points left on the field, and four points is more than the gap between a three-point win and a one-point loss.

¹⁰Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2025 regular season: extra points 1,210 of 1,262 good (95.9%); two-point tries 59 of 128 successful (46.1%). Safeties: 12 in 272 games.

¹¹NFL.com, “NFL moves extra point to 15-yard line for 2015 season” (May 19, 2015), on the 30–2 vote and the new defensive two-point return: <https://www.nfl.com/news/nfl-moves-extra-point-to-15-yard-line-for-2015-season-0ap3000000493347>. Make rates are a course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, regular season: 99.3% in 2014, 94.2% in 2015.

¹²The AFL used the two-point conversion from 1960 to 1969; the NFL adopted it at the owners’ meeting of March 22, 1994. Wikipedia, “Two-point conversion”: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Two-point_conversion

¹³Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2025 regular season, field goals by kick distance: under 30 yards 98.1% (210 attempts), 30–39 93.0% (299), 40–49 84.3% (313), 50–59 70.1% (244), 60 and longer 54.5% (22).

¹⁴*Official Playing Rules of the NFL* (2026), Rule 11-4-2 (after a missed field goal, the receivers’ ball at the spot of the kick, or at the 20-yard line if the kick was from inside the 20): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

¹⁵*Official Playing Rules of the NFL* (2026), Rule 11-5-1 (when it is a safety) and Rule 6-1-2 (the safety kick, made from the kicking team’s own 20-yard line): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

¹⁶Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play (*fixed_drive_result*, *drive_inside20*), 2025 regular season. Drives that reached the opponent’s 20: touchdown 57.3%, field goal 29.5%, turnover on downs 5.5%, turnover 4.8%, missed field goal 1.4%, end of half 1.2%. All drives: touchdown 23.1%, field goal 16.2%.

The scoring system leaves its fingerprint on the final scores. Because points arrive in lumps of 3 and 7 (and 8, 6 and 2 now and then), certain margins of victory are far more common than others.

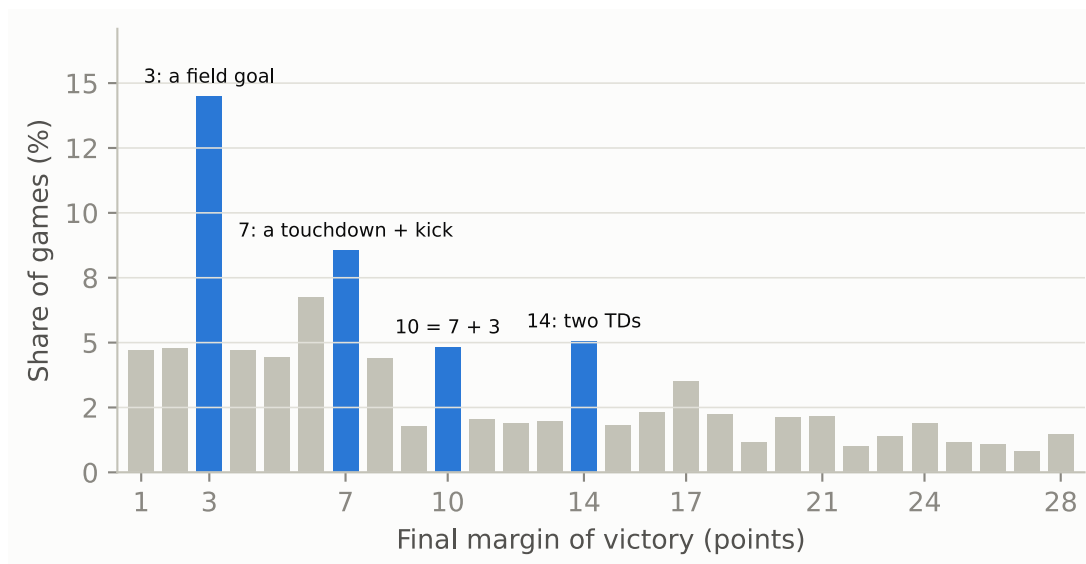


Figure 4: How many points the winner won by: every NFL regular-season game from 2016 through 2025 (2,629 games; the 10 ties are left out). Three points (one field goal) is by far the most common margin, and 7 (one touchdown and its kick) is second. The steps at 10 and 14 are combinations of the same lumps.

That chart is why announcers say “a one-score game”. With the two-point try, one possession can be worth as many as eight points, so a lead of 8 or less can be erased by a single drive and a lead of 9 or more can’t. About half of NFL games end within one score of each other, which is a large part of why the end of the game, and the clock, matter so much.¹⁷

i Film room: Seahawks 2025

Super Bowl LX (February 8, 2026, Seattle 29, New England 13) was a lopsided game on the field and, for three quarters, a close one on the scoreboard. Seattle’s offense kept getting inside the Patriots’ 25-yard line and kept settling for field goals: Jason Myers kicked from 33, 39, 41 and 41 yards in the first three quarters, a Super Bowl record five field goals in all, including a 26-yarder on fourth-and-4 from the 8 in the fourth quarter. After three quarters Seattle led only 12–0. It was dominant, but a team that has kicked four field goals instead of scoring four touchdowns has left 16 points on the field, and a two-touchdown lead is a lead the other team can still catch. A New England touchdown early in the fourth made it 19–7. Seattle didn’t put the game away until Uchenna Nwosu returned an interception 45 yards for a touchdown with 4:37 left.¹⁸

What to notice: count the trips that end in three instead of seven. A team winning on field goals is winning, but it’s also leaving the door open.

The shape of a game

Football has a fixed skeleton, and once you know it the broadcast stops feeling like a stream of unrelated plays.

Coin toss and kickoff. A few minutes before the start, the referee tosses a coin at midfield and the visiting captain calls it. The winner chooses whether to receive the opening kickoff, to kick, or which end to defend, or can **defer** the choice to the second half, which many winners now do so they’re sure to get the ball to start the second half.¹⁹ The game starts with a kickoff: one team kicks the ball from its own 35 to the other, which tries to return it. (The NFL has rewritten its kickoff rules three times since 2024; that chapter has the current version.)

¹⁷Course calculation from nflverse schedules ([load_schedules](#)), regular seasons 2016–2025. In 2025, 15.1% of games were decided by exactly 3 points, 9.6% by exactly 7, and 53% by 8 points or fewer.

¹⁸Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, game [2025_22_SEA_NE](#): Myers field goals of 33 (Q1), 39 and 41 (Q2), 41 (Q3) and 26 yards (Q4, fourth-and-4 at the 8); Barner 16-yard touchdown catch (Q4, 13:29); Nwosu 45-yard interception return (Q4, 4:37). Result and Myers’s record: Wikipedia, “Super Bowl LX”: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_LX

¹⁹*Official Playing Rules of the NFL* (2026), Rule 4-2-2 (toss of coin; the option to defer): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

Possessions. From then on, the game is a series of **possessions**. The team with the ball, the offense, keeps it until it scores, kicks it away (a punt), fails to gain the yards it needs on fourth down, or loses it to an interception or fumble. Then the other team gets its turn. The possessions alternate like innings, and there aren't many of them: in 2025 each team had about 10 or 11 per game, and the average team ran about 60 plays from scrimmage.²⁰ That scarcity is the key to almost every strategic decision in this course. A team that wastes one possession has wasted a tenth of its game.

Quarters. The game is 60 minutes of game-clock time, divided into four **quarters** of 15 minutes each. After the first and third quarters the teams swap ends, so that wind and sun are shared fairly; the ball, the down and the distance stay exactly as they were, just at the other end. A possession doesn't stop at the end of the first or third quarter; it simply continues after the teams change ends.²¹

Halftime. After the second quarter comes halftime, 13 minutes in a normal game (much longer at the Super Bowl, where the halftime show runs). The second half starts with a fresh kickoff, usually by the team that received to start the game. Halftime is a hard reset in one important way: an unfinished drive at the end of the second quarter is simply over. So both halves have their own endgame, and you'll see the clock-management fight twice a game, before halftime and at the end.

Overtime. If the score is tied after four quarters, the game goes to an overtime period. Since the 2025 season both teams are guaranteed a possession in regular-season overtime, as they have been in the playoffs since 2022; regular-season overtime lasts 10 minutes and can still end in a tie, while playoff games keep playing 15-minute periods until someone wins.²² The details (who gets the ball, what ends it, how the timeouts work) are in *The Clock*, *the Two-Minute Drill*, and *Fourth Down*.

A game of 60 minutes takes about three hours to play. The gap is the subject of the rest of this chapter: the clock stops a lot, and even when it's running, most of that time is spent between plays. One often-cited count of televised games found only about 11 minutes of actual action, from snap to whistle, in a typical broadcast.²³

i Film room: Eagles 2024

Super Bowl LIX (February 9, 2025, Caesars Superdome, New Orleans) makes a good first game to walk through, because it used almost every scoring method in this chapter. Philadelphia beat Kansas City 40–22.²⁴ The figure below puts every scoring play on the field, with both offenses shown attacking to the right, and then lays the score out over the 60 minutes of the game.

²⁰Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2025 regular season: 10.6 drives per team per game (**fixed_drive**, including short end-of-half possessions) and 123 runs, passes, kneels and spikes per game, about 61 per team.

²¹*Official Playing Rules of the NFL* (2026), Rule 4, Section 1 (four 15-minute periods; a 13-minute halftime) and Rule 4-2-3 (change of goals after the first and third periods, with possession, down, distance and yard line unchanged): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

²²*Official Playing Rules of the NFL* (2026), Rule 16 (regular season: one 10-minute period, both teams must have the opportunity to possess, ties possible; postseason: 15-minute periods until there is a winner); on the 2022 (playoff) and 2025 (regular season) changes, NFL Football Operations, featured rules: <https://operations.nfl.com/rules-officiating/featured-rules>

²³David Biderman, "11 Minutes of Action," *The Wall Street Journal*, January 15, 2010: <https://www.wsj.com/articles/SB10001424052748704281204575002852055561406>

²⁴Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, game 2024_22_KC_PHI (scoring plays, times and the running score); result: NFL.com and the course fact sheet (Eagles 40, Chiefs 22; Jalen Hurts MVP): <https://www.nfl.com/news/eagles-dominate-chiefs-40-22-in-super-bowl-lix-to-win-second-championship-in-franchise-history>

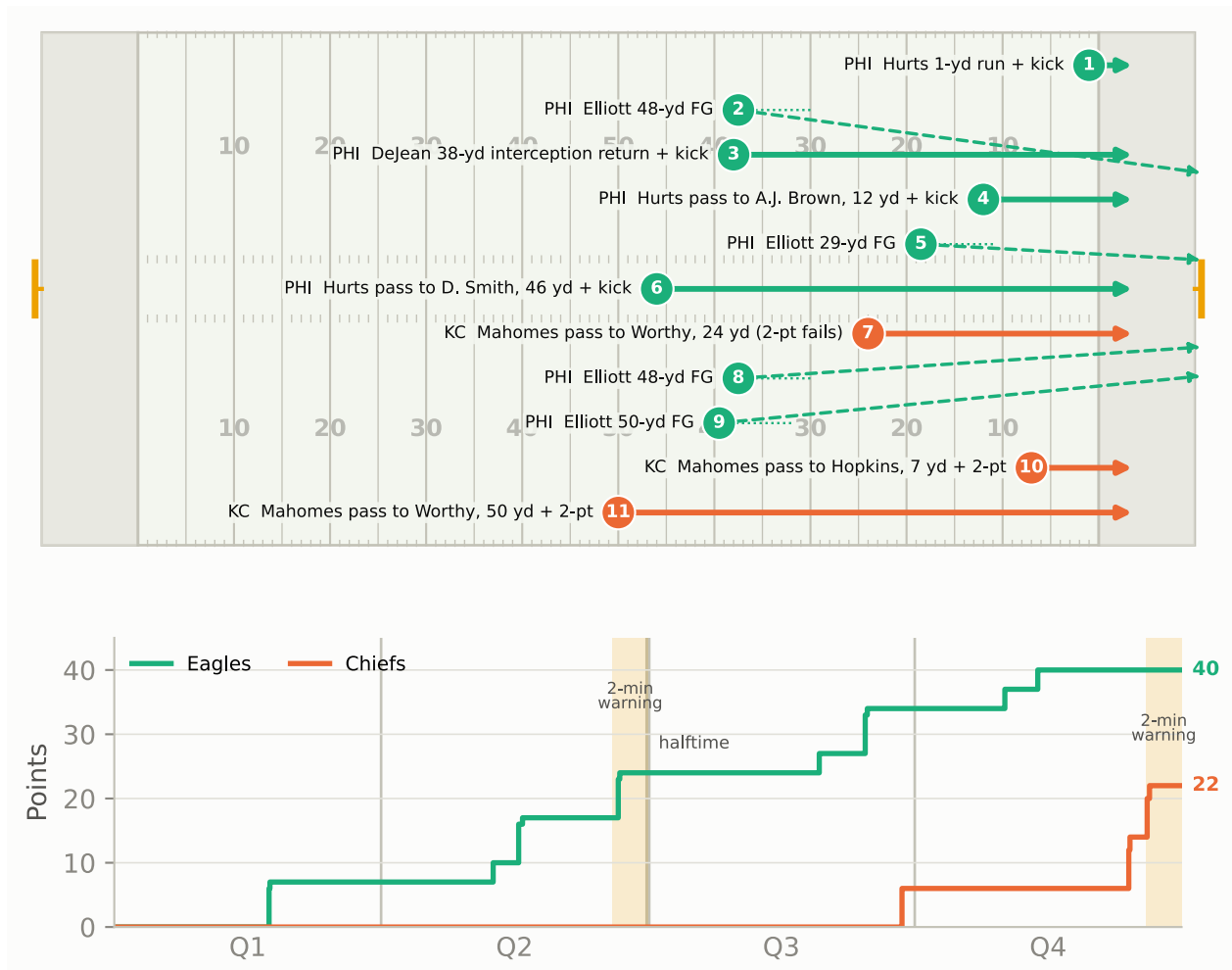


Figure 5: Super Bowl LIX, every scoring play (top), drawn with both offenses attacking right. Each row starts at the line of scrimmage of the scoring play: a solid arrow for a touchdown, a dashed ball path for a field goal. DeJean’s touchdown (3) starts where he intercepted the pass. Bottom: the score over the game’s 60 minutes of game-clock time, with the two-minute warnings and halftime marked. Points after touchdowns are folded into each touchdown’s row.

Things to notice in that game:

- **Every one of the five scoring plays except the safety shows up.** The Eagles’ first touchdown was Jalen Hurts’s 1-yard quarterback push from the 1 (the play called the tush push, which the league debated banning a few months later). Their third was scored by the *defense*: Cooper DeJean intercepted Patrick Mahomes and returned it 38 yards. Jake Elliott kicked four field goals and four extra points.
- **The trailing team went for two, three times.** Kansas City, down 34–0 and later 40–6, tried the two-point conversion after each of its touchdowns, made two of three, and still lost by 18. When you’re far behind, a kick’s one point barely matters; you need every possession to be worth as much as possible.
- **A big lead changes how the clock is used.** Look at the score line over time: Philadelphia led 24–0 at halftime and 34–0 late in the third quarter. From there the Eagles’ job was simply to make the remaining minutes disappear, and Kansas City’s was the opposite. The rest of this chapter is about how each side does that.
- **The two-minute warning reshapes the end of a half.** Philadelphia’s touchdown pass to A.J. Brown came with 1:40 left in the second quarter, after the warning, on a drive Kansas City tried to stop with its timeouts. The last two minutes of each half are played under slightly different clock rules, which we’ll get to next.

Two clocks, not one

Look at the corner of any broadcast and you’ll find the score bug: a strip with the teams, the score, the quarter, and two different clocks.

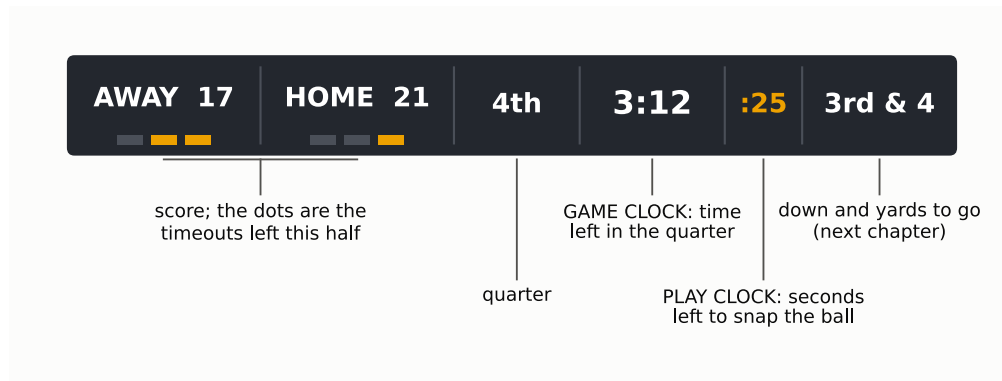


Figure 6: A generic broadcast score bug, labelled. The big clock is the game clock (time left in the quarter); the small one is the play clock (seconds left to snap the ball). The dots under each team are its remaining timeouts for this half.

The **game clock** is the big one. It counts down each 15-minute quarter, but only while time is “in”. Whenever it’s stopped, nothing that happens uses up any of the 60 minutes, which is exactly why teams fight over when it stops.

The **play clock** is the small one, usually in a different color, and it counts something else entirely: how long the offense has to snap the ball. In the NFL it starts at **40 seconds** the moment the previous play ends. After an administrative stoppage, such as a timeout, a change of possession, a penalty being marked off, the two-minute warning, or the start of a quarter, it’s set to **25 seconds** instead, starting when the referee signals that the ball is ready.²⁵ If it hits zero before the snap, the offense is penalized five yards for delay of game.

The two clocks run independently, and the interesting part is how they interact. When the game clock is running between plays, every second the offense takes to snap the ball is a second of the game gone. An offense that’s ahead can let the play clock run down to 1 before every snap and spend almost 40 seconds of game clock per play. An offense that’s behind wants the opposite: snap quickly, or stop the game clock, or both.

i Madden vs. real life

In a video game the clock seems to be about the plays: you pick a play, it runs, a few seconds come off. In a real NFL game, most of the game clock disappears *between* plays, while players unpile, jog back, huddle and line up, with the game clock still running. Forty seconds of play clock against five or six seconds of actual play means a running clock can burn 35 to 40 seconds per snap. That’s why the question that matters isn’t “how long did the play take?” but “**did the play stop the clock?**”

When the clock stops, and why

So when *does* the game clock stop? The rules list them precisely, but they boil down to a handful of situations, and each exists for a reason.

²⁵Official Playing Rules of the NFL (2026), Rule 4, Section 6, Articles 1–2 (40-second play clock from the end of a play; 25 seconds after a change of possession, a charged timeout, the two-minute warning, the end of a period, a penalty enforcement and other administrative stoppages): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

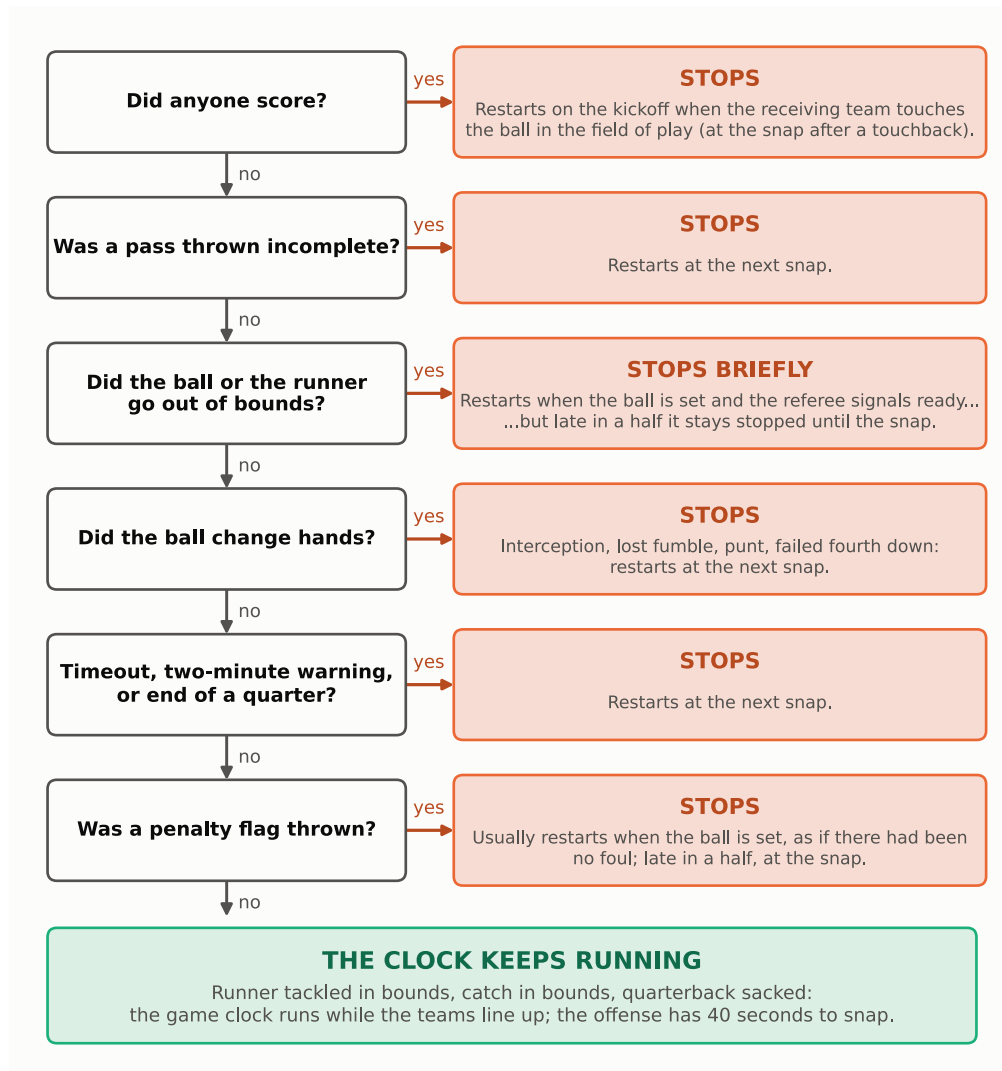


Figure 7: After this play, does the game clock run? Work down the questions; the first ‘yes’ decides it. If none applies, the clock keeps running while the teams line up for the next snap. ‘Late in a half’ means after the two-minute warning of the first half or inside the last five minutes of the game.

Take the stoppages one at a time.

- **Scores.** After a touchdown or field goal the clock stops, the try is untimed, and the clock doesn’t restart until the kickoff is caught or touched in the field of play. A touchback (the kick downed in or beyond the end zone) means it starts at the next snap. The reason is simple fairness: the team that just gave up points shouldn’t also lose time while the scoring team celebrates and kicks off.
- **Incomplete passes.** The clock stops and stays stopped until the next snap. Why? An incomplete pass is a dead ball that the officials must retrieve and re-spot, and a passing team shouldn’t be charged game time for that. It also produces one of football’s most important trade-offs: **passes stop the clock when they fail and runs almost never do.** A team that’s ahead runs the ball partly to keep the clock moving; a team that’s behind throws partly because an incompletion at least doesn’t cost it time.
- **Out of bounds.** This is the one most viewers get wrong. For most of the game, a runner who goes out of bounds stops the clock only *briefly*: it restarts as soon as the officials have spotted the ball and the referee signals it ready, a matter of seconds. But **after the two-minute warning of the first half, and in the last five minutes of the game**, the clock stays stopped until the next snap.²⁶ That’s the rule behind the hook at the top of this chapter. The leading team’s runner went down in bounds because, late in the game, stepping out would have stopped the clock and handed the other team 30-odd seconds. The trailing team’s receiver ran out because he wanted exactly that. (The Clock, the Two-Minute Drill, and Fourth Down has the full rule and how teams use it.)

²⁶Official Playing Rules of the NFL (2026), Rule 4-3-2(a): when a runner goes out of bounds, the game clock starts on the referee’s ready-for-play signal, except that it starts on the snap after a change of possession, after the two-minute warning of the first half, or inside the last five minutes of the second half. Rule 4, Section 4 lists every event that stops the clock: <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

- **Change of possession.** When the ball changes hands, by an interception, a fumble the defense recovers, a punt, or a failed fourth down, the clock stops at the end of the play and restarts at the next snap. Both teams need to send different players on, and the rule lets them.
- **Timeouts, the two-minute warning, and the end of a quarter.** All stop the clock until the next snap.
- **Penalties.** A flag stops the clock while it's sorted out, and for most of the game the clock then restarts as if the foul hadn't happened. Late in each half it restarts at the snap instead, so that a team can't commit a foul to run time off.

What *doesn't* stop the clock matters just as much. A runner tackled in bounds, a completed pass caught in bounds, and a quarterback sacked behind the line all leave the clock running. And in the NFL, so does a **first down**.

Common misconception

"The clock stops on a first down." In college football it used to stop briefly after every first down; since 2023 it does so only in the last two minutes of each half. In the NFL it never stops for a first down. The only time a first down stops the NFL clock is when the officials need a measurement to decide whether the ball made it, which they handle as a referee's timeout.²⁷ If you grew up watching Saturday games, this is the habit to unlearn first.

Timeouts and the two-minute warning

A **timeout** is a team's way to stop the clock on demand. Each team gets **three per half**; unused first-half timeouts don't carry over into the second half. The head coach or any player on the field can ask for one, but only while the ball is dead.²⁸ Teams use timeouts for three different reasons, and you can usually tell which from the moment it's called:

1. **To save time.** The trailing team, late in a half, stops the clock after a play that would otherwise let it run.
2. **To fix a problem.** The play clock is about to expire, the wrong players are on the field, or the quarterback doesn't like what he sees and there's no time to change the play.
3. **To make the other team think.** Before an important fourth down or a long field goal, a defense sometimes calls timeout to "ice" the kicker or to see the offense's personnel before committing.

Because there are only three, a timeout used early to fix a problem is one the team won't have in the final two minutes, when it might be worth a whole possession. Watch for announcers wincing at a first-half timeout called because the offense couldn't get lined up.

The **two-minute warning** is an automatic, free timeout. When the game clock passes 2:00 in the second or fourth quarter, the clock stops at the end of whatever play is running.²⁹ It's a commercial break, but it's also a strategic landmark: it's effectively a fourth timeout for the team trying to save time, and it's where the out-of-bounds rule tightens in the first half. A trailing team with the ball at 2:30 knows the clock will stop for free in thirty seconds; a leading team can't kneel its way past it.

How the clock and the scoreboard work together

Put the clock rules and the scoring together and the end of a close game starts to explain itself. The team that's **ahead** wants the clock running: it calls runs, keeps the ball carrier in bounds, snaps the ball late in the play clock, and lets the other team burn its timeouts. The team that's **behind** wants it stopped: it throws, especially toward the sideline, where a completion can be followed by a step out of bounds; it snaps quickly; and it spends its timeouts on the other team's plays. Each side's possession is worth a certain number of points *and* a certain number of seconds, and good coaches price both.

Those are the broad strokes. The precise tools (the spike, the kneel-down, the 10-second runoff, the two-minute drill, the four-minute offense that tries to run out the clock) and how coaches decide between them are in The Clock, the Two-Minute Drill, and Fourth Down. You don't need them yet. You need the habit of asking, before every snap late in a half, whether the clock is running and who that helps.

²⁷ *Official Playing Rules of the NFL* (2026), Rule 4-5-5(a) (a referee's timeout when there is the possibility of a measurement for a first down): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. On the college change, NCAA, "Football rules changes approved" (2023): <https://www.ncaa.org/news/2023/4/21/media-center-football-rules-changes-approved.aspx>

²⁸ *Official Playing Rules of the NFL* (2026), Rule 4-5-1 (three charged team timeouts per half; requested by the head coach or any player; granted only when the ball is dead): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

²⁹ *Official Playing Rules of the NFL* (2026), Rule 3, Section 41 (the two-minute warning "is an automatic timeout that occurs at the conclusion of the last down for which the ball is legally snapped or kicked prior to two minutes remaining on the game clock in the second and fourth periods"): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

💡 Watch for it

Clock watcher (one quarter). Pick a quarter, ideally the second or the fourth. Before each snap, say out loud: “Clock running” or “Clock stopped”, and why.

Before the snap

- Which hash is the ball on? Name the field side and the boundary side.
- Look at the score bug: game clock moving or frozen? How much is left on the play clock?
- How many timeouts does each team have (the dots)?

After the play

- Did anyone score? Incomplete pass? Out of bounds? Ball change hands? Flag?
- If it went out of bounds: are we after the first-half two-minute warning or inside the last five minutes? Then the clock stays stopped until the snap.
- If none of those happened, the clock is running. Count how long the offense takes to snap it.

What to record. Tally how many of your calls you got right, and note any play that surprised you. By the end of the quarter, you’ll find you’re no longer guessing, and you’ll start predicting what a team *wants* the clock to do before it does it.

Predict the play

💡 Predict the play

Which way is the room? First-and-10 at the offense’s own 35, second quarter. The ball is on the offense’s *right* hash. The offense lines up with three receivers to its left and one to its right.

1st & 10, ball on the right hash

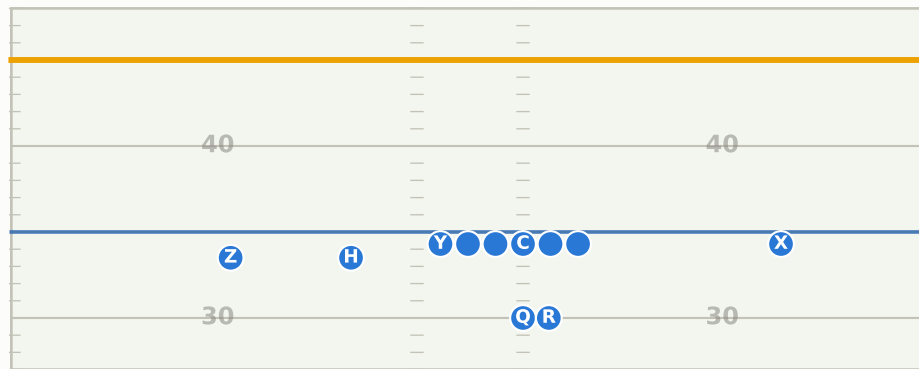


Figure 8: First-and-10, ball on the offense’s right hash. Three receivers line up to the offense’s left (top-left of the picture is the offense’s left as it attacks up the page), one to its right. Which side is the field side, and why put three receivers there?

Which is the field side here? Which is the boundary? Why would the offense put three receivers on the side it did?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Predict the play

Stay in or go out? Fourth quarter, 3:40 left. The offense leads 24–20 and has the ball. The running back takes a handoff, gets around the corner, and is running along the sideline toward midfield with defenders closing in.

4th quarter, 3:40, leading 24-20

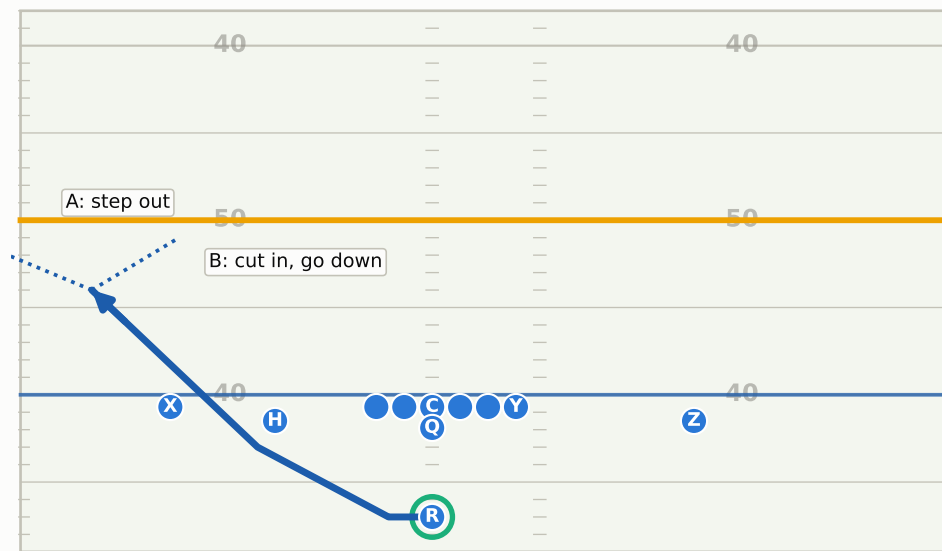


Figure 9: Leading 24–20 with 3:40 left in the fourth quarter. The running back (highlighted) breaks a run toward the boundary; at the end of the solid path he can step out of bounds (A) or cut inside and go down in bounds (B). Which should he do?

What should the runner do, and why? Would your answer change if it were the *second* quarter with 9:40 left?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play

What is this? The offense has just scored a touchdown with 0:41 left in the game. Before the touchdown it trailed 21–13; now it's 21–19. It lines up for its try like this.

The try, 0:41 left, trailing 21-19

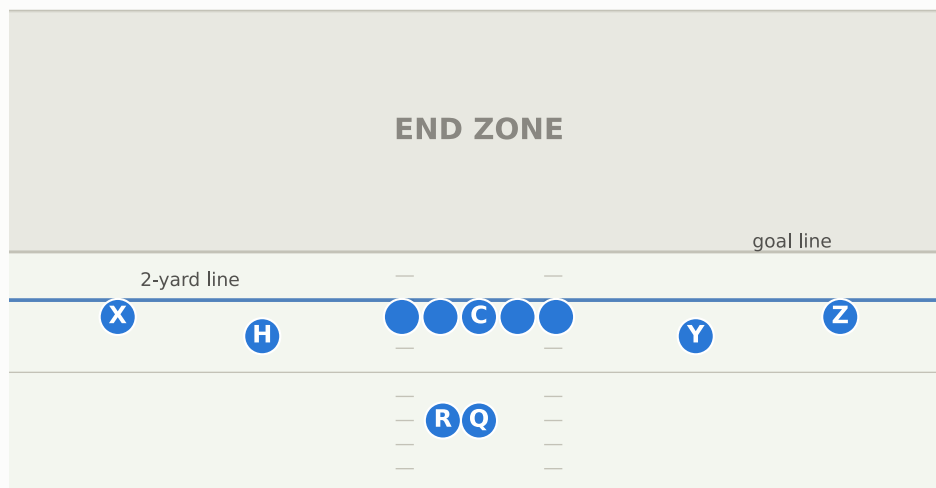


Figure 10: After a touchdown with 0:41 left: the scoring team lines up at the 2-yard line, in shotgun with four receivers spread out, and no kicker or holder in sight.

What is the offense attempting, and why not just kick?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- The field is **120 by 53⅓ yards**: two 10-yard **end zones** behind the **goal lines**, yard lines every 5 numbered up to the 50 from each end, and **hash marks** down the middle. The goal line belongs to the end zone, so the ball only has to touch its plane.
- **Every play starts on or between the hashes**, so most snaps come from a hash, which splits the field into a **field (wide) side** and a **boundary (short) side**. Offenses usually put their strength toward the room; defenses assign players by side. College's wider hashes make the effect far stronger than in the NFL.
- Points come in lumps: **6** for a touchdown, **1** or **2** for the try after it, **3** for a field goal, **2** for a safety. Because the kick is about as valuable on average as the two-point try, the scoreboard decides which a team chooses.
- **Seven versus three** is the central tension: a red-zone trip that ends in a field goal leaves four points behind. It's why 3 and 7 are the most common final margins, and why a lead of 8 or less is "one score".
- The **game clock** stops for scores, incompletions, changes of possession, timeouts, the two-minute warning, and penalties; out of bounds stops it only briefly, **except late in a half**. The **play clock** (40 seconds, or 25 after a stoppage) is the offense's deadline to snap.
- Possessions are scarce, about 10 or 11 per team, so **time is a resource**: the team ahead wants the clock running, the team behind wants it stopped, and nearly every late-game choice follows from that.

Connections

Builds on: nothing; this is the starting line.

Sets up: Downs, Distance, and Field Position fills in the rest of the scoreboard graphic (downs, the line to gain, field position as a currency) and introduces expected points, which turns this chapter's 7-versus-3 into numbers. The Twenty-Two introduces the players who line up on this field, and What a Play Really Is follows a play call through the 40-second play clock. Further on, The Clock, the Two-Minute Drill, and Fourth Down finishes the clock (overtime, the full out-of-bounds rule, kneel-downs, spikes and the 10-second runoff); Field Goals, Extra Points, and the Punting Game and Kickoffs, Returns, and the Dynamic Kickoff cover the

kicking game; Win Probability and Decision Analysis prices the go-for-two and field-goal decisions; and Coverage Fundamentals uses the field and boundary sides to assign defenders.

Case studies: the Super Bowl LIX Eagles reappear in The Eagles: Trenches, RPOs, and the Tush Push, and the Super Bowl LX Seahawks in Fangio’s Two-High Revolution and Macdonald’s Answer.

Go deeper

- The *Official Playing Rules of the NFL* are free on NFL Football Operations (operations.nfl.com). Rule 1 (the field), Rule 4 (timing) and Rule 11 (scoring) are short and readable, and they’re the source for most of this chapter.
- NFL Football Operations’ “Learn the Game” pages have plain-language summaries of the basic rules and a glossary of terms.
- Pat Kirwan, *Take Your Eye Off the Ball* (2010; 2nd ed. 2015), opens with how to watch a broadcast, including the field position and clock cues this chapter introduces.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

The ball is on the offense’s **right** hash, so the **boundary (short) side** is to the right, about 23½ yards to the sideline, and the **field (wide) side** is to the left, about 30 yards. The offense has put its three receivers **to the field side**, where there is room for three of them to spread out and run routes without crowding each other or the sideline, and left one receiver alone to the boundary.

That’s the most common way to set up a formation in the NFL: strength to the field. It puts the most bodies where there is the most space, and it forces the defense to send more of its players toward the wide side to cover them, which can leave the lone boundary receiver one-on-one near the sideline. Not every team does it every time (some deliberately put their strength into the boundary to surprise the defense), but on any given snap “three to the field” is the safe guess. Formations get their own names and rules in Spread Formations.

Answer 2.

Stay in bounds (B). With 3:40 left in the fourth quarter, the game is inside its last five minutes, so a runner who goes out of bounds stops the game clock **until the next snap**. If he goes down in bounds instead, the clock keeps running while the offense lines up, and the offense can let the play clock run down before it snaps: that’s up to 40 more seconds gone from the trailing team’s comeback. The leading team wants the game to end; every stopped clock is time it hands back. (If he can score untouched, he should, of course. A 28–20 lead is worth more than 40 seconds.)

In the **second quarter with 9:40 left**, it barely matters. Outside the last two minutes of the first half and the last five of the game, a runner going out of bounds stops the clock only until the ball is spotted and the referee signals it ready, a few seconds, and then it runs again. So early in the game, runners fight for the extra yard along the sideline and step out freely; late in the game, the leading team’s runners stay in and the trailing team’s receivers run out. Watch the same player make opposite choices in the first and fourth quarters.

Answer 3.

It’s a **two-point conversion**. The tell is the spot: the ball is on the **2-yard line**, not the 15, and there’s no holder kneeling seven yards back, just a quarterback in shotgun and four receivers.

The scoreboard makes the choice for the coach. Trailing 21–19 with 41 seconds left, a kicked extra point would make it 21–20, still a loss unless the defense gets the ball back and the offense scores again in under 41 seconds. The two-point try, if it works, ties the game at 21 and sends it toward overtime. It succeeds a little under half the time (46% in 2025), but a kick, though almost certain, leaves the team short. This is the “trailing by eight” situation from the scoring section: an 8-point deficit is exactly one touchdown *plus* a two-point conversion, which is why 8 is the largest lead that one possession can erase.